

An Enchanted World

This classic adventure of wizards and magicians is India's answer to Harry Potter



HOSHRUBA: THE LAND AND THE TILISM

by MUHAMMAD
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Translated by
MUSHARRAF ALI
FAROOQI

Random House India

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| By Gillian Wright |

Amir Hamza, once a mere footnote in literary history, has been very seriously rediscovered now that within the space of two years, Random House has published two fat volumes of his adventures translated from the original Urdu by the gifted writer Musharraf Ali Farooqi. The latest of these volumes, *Hoshrubah*, is again a magnificent translation of what was once thought untranslatable, full of humour, verve and just the right amount of old-style language to capture the legendary world of Hamza. In Delhi, another Farooqi, Mahmood, and his colleagues have single-handedly espoused the lost art of live storytelling of the Hamza adventures in the Urdu *dastaan* tradition, performing to enthusiastic audiences. But many of the people who would love to be able to appreciate Urdu *dastaans* are defeated by the language. In this horribly Anglo-centric age in which we live, there is therefore a real need for Farooqi's translation.

It did strike me, as I dived into another wizard battle, that this latest cycle of Hamza adventures could be India's answer to Harry Potter. Like J.K. Rowling, the authors of the Urdu Hoshrubah adventures drew from tradition but invented something entirely their own. Farooqi, in his introduction, explains that the Hoshrubah adventures had not been handed down from

generation to generation by word of mouth like other Hamza tales. Instead they were invented in 19th century Lucknow by a band of literary conspirators who presented them as newly discovered ancient tales to give them the authority of tradition. The Hoshrubah tales are, therefore, a thoroughly Indian addition to adventure stories that were international in their appeal and began to develop around the 7th century.

In this book, Amir Hamza, the main character in traditional tales and thought to be based on an uncle of the Prophet Muhammad, is peripheral to the plot. The hero is instead Asad, the Lion, Hamza's grandson. His battleground is Hoshrubah, a magical land or *tilism*, divided into different provinces, informed with magic at every step, and ruled by wizards and magicians of mind-blowing capabilities. Asad's task is to rescue his father, Hamza's son, and to destroy Hoshrubah's supreme leader, Afrasiyab. Asad is referred to throughout as the Conqueror of the Tilism, and so you have the comfort of knowing that there will be a happy ending. Fate is obviously on his side. But the roads to this end are not clear and fraught with danger and the strangest happenings. Asad is human, knows no magic, and is therefore clearly ill-equipped to battle with wizards. At one point his beloved—naturally there is one—casts a spell on his horse so that it develops wings, carries him by force from the battlefield, and keeps him out of harm's way. Girl-power indeed.

But luckily Asad has on his side five roguish tricksters led by the fantastical Amar Ayyar, who has a head like a dried gourd, eyes the size of cumin seeds, ears like apricots, cheeks resembling breadcake, a thread-like neck and limbs like rope. His lower body is six yards long and upper body three. He and his companions are masters of disguise and untroubled by morality. They fight the enemy magicians and demons and provide continuous entertainment.

Among the myriad Indian elements in these tales are sadhus, elephants, a Ravana-like abduction of an innocent maiden and a character mixing parched gram flour, or *sattu*, with water to make the traditional drink of the poor in rural north India. In short, this is a tour de force of Indian literature, and Farooqi has done a great service by making it accessible to English readers. ■

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